mosque. The debates were now different in detail. The BJP was in its sixth year of continuous majority power in India, but the underlying touchpoints of cultural and political contention that its rise had engendered—on what it means to be Indian in a Hindu-majority but non-sectarian State—were essentially the same.

A couple of months after the appearance of the ‘Jai Sri Ram’ sticker, I accompanied my father when he went to pick up my mother from her Union government ministry office in Delhi’s RK Puram. Her co-workers, lower-level bureaucrats, had set up a shrine to the Hindu gods Ram, Shiva and Krishna in a corner of their shared office space. Next to it, someone had pasted a new sticker. It sported the visage of a martial Ram with a bow and arrow and a one-line message: ‘Mandir Vahin Banaayenge’ (We will build the temple right there). This was another rallying cry of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement—an assertion that the temple would only be built on the site of the Babri mosque, no matter what. My father, who was in his olive-green Army uniform, stiffened when he saw the slogan inside the government building. ‘They have taken an oath to be apolitical in government service,’ he said. ‘All this should be fought outside, not here.’ I was too young to understand it at the time, but my mother’s office wall reflected another fissure that the Ram movement had opened up: on the role of the State and its officials when their private religious and political beliefs clashed with expected behaviour, especially when these beliefs were being vehemently, and politically, contested.

By the time L.K. Advani’s rath, a souped-up Toyota truck rejigged to look like a medieval chariot, wound its way through India, I was in boarding school. We were participating in school debates with topics like ‘There Is No Place for Religion in a Democracy: For or Against’ or ‘Our Culture Is Our Greatest Strength: For or Against’. Most students did not really care about these topics; they were just school assignments. Yet, in an India without internet or mobile phones, in the secluded, sheltered surroundings of our elite boarding school, a couple of senior boys were excited enough by the Ram movement to keep a daily pictorial scrapbook on the Rath Yatra and its day-to-day travails, with cuttings from newspapers and weekly magazines. The din of the Ram Mandir movement was all around us,